FOR ANYONE WITH A GAP AFTER A LAYOFF

The Gap-Proof Résumé Kit

Turn a layoff gap into interview calls. ATS-friendly résumé & cover letter templates, plus *40 fill-in gap explanations* you can use today.

GAP

Inside:

3 résumé templates (Word & Google Docs) · 3 cover letters
Gap Explanation Bank · bullet-rewrite formula · ATS checklist
LinkedIn "Open to Work" fill-ins · full before & after example

The Gap-Proof Résumé Kit

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The example people and résumés in this kit are made up. They show the kinds of situations that come up again and again after a layoff.

This kit gives general advice about résumés and job applications. Nobody can promise you interviews or a job offer. What this kit can do is help you present your experience, and your gap, clearly and honestly.

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What’s in your download

Start here: your résumé in one evening

You've been sending out your old résumé for weeks. Maybe months. And every time you attach it, you look at those dates at the top and feel your stomach drop. *March 2025 – present* is no longer true. There's a hole now, and it seems to get bigger every time you look at it.

This kit is built for exactly that feeling. It won't hide your gap, because hiding it doesn't work and isn't honest. What it will do is help you **explain it in one calm line**, fill it with what you actually did, and make the rest of your résumé strong enough that the gap becomes a footnote.

Everything you need is in this download:

- **3 résumé templates** (Word and Google Docs friendly), built to pass applicant tracking systems
- **3 cover letters** for a recent layoff, a longer gap, and a career pivot
- **This guide**, with the Gap Explanation Bank, worksheets and a full before-and-after example

The one-evening plan (about 2 hours)

Time	Do this	Where
10 min	Read chapter 1, so you stop worrying about the wrong things	Ch. 1
10 min	Pick your template	Ch. 2
20 min	Find your gap line in the Gap Explanation Bank and adapt it	Ch. 3 and 4
20 min	Fill in the gap-time worksheet	Ch. 5
30 min	Move your experience into the template and rewrite your bullets	Ch. 6
20 min	Fill in the matching cover letter	Ch. 7
10 min	Run the ATS checklist and save as PDF	Ch. 8

Then tomorrow, with fresh eyes, read it out loud once and fix anything that sounds stiff.

One rule for everything that follows: **never write anything that isn't true.** Recruiters check dates, references and LinkedIn. A clear, honest gap is easy to get past. A made-up job is not.

1. What a recruiter actually thinks about a gap

When you've been out of work for a while, it's easy to imagine that every recruiter sees your gap and immediately hits delete. It helps to know what's actually going on on the other side.

Gaps are common. Layoffs come in waves, and long job searches happen to good people in every field. Recruiters see résumés with gaps every single day. Many of them have had one themselves.

What worries them isn't the gap. It's not knowing why. An unexplained hole invites guesses, and people tend to guess the worst. A single honest line ("Career break: caring for a family member") removes most of that worry before it starts.

They skim fast. A first look at a résumé is often very quick. In that short time a recruiter is looking for three things: does this person have the skills for the job, can I see results, and is there anything strange I need to ask about? Your job is to make the first two obvious and the third one boring.

Recent and relevant beats perfect and continuous. A résumé that shows you've been learning, doing freelance work or volunteering during the gap often reads better than one that tries to stretch the old job's dates.

So the goal of this kit isn't to make your gap disappear. It's to make it **clear, short and uninteresting**, so the recruiter's attention goes where you want it: to what you can do for them.

2. Choose your template

You get three résumé templates. All three are single-column, use standard section headings and contain no tables, text boxes or graphics, which are the things that most often confuse applicant tracking systems.

Template	Best for	Length
1. Classic	Most people. Up to about 8 years of experience, a gap of up to a year	1 page
2. Experienced	8+ years of experience, several roles, or a senior position	2 pages
3. Career Change	Moving into a new field after the layoff, or a gap longer than a year	1 to 2 pages

Not sure? Choose Classic. A clean one-page résumé is rarely the wrong choice.

What's different about the Career Change template? It opens with a short summary and a "Relevant skills" section before your work history. That way the recruiter sees what you can do for *this* job before they see a timeline that includes a gap or a different field.

How to open the files

- **Microsoft Word:** double-click the `.docx` file.
- **Google Docs:** go to drive.google.com, upload the `.docx` file, then right-click it and choose *Open with → Google Docs*.

- **Pages (Mac):** open the `.docx` file in Pages. Check the spacing afterwards, as Pages sometimes shifts it slightly.

When you're done, always **save or export as PDF** before you send it, unless the job ad specifically asks for a Word file.

3. Where the gap goes on your résumé

There are three ways to handle a gap on the page. Which one you choose depends mostly on how long it is.

Under 3 months: leave it

A gap of a few weeks or two months is a normal job search. You don't need to mention it on your résumé at all. If you're asked in an interview, one sentence is enough.

3 to 12 months: one honest line

Add a short entry in your experience section, in the same format as a job, so it fits the timeline:

> ***Career break: job search and professional development*** | *Jun 2025 – Present*
>
> - *Completed Google Project Management Certificate (2025)*
> - *Freelance bookkeeping for 3 local small businesses*

The entry does two things at once. It explains the time, and it shows you used it. Chapter 4 has the exact wording for different reasons, and chapter 5 helps you find what to put underneath.

Over 12 months: line plus summary

For a longer gap, add the line *and* mention your direction in the summary at the top of the résumé, so the recruiter reads your story before they see the dates:

> *Operations coordinator with 7 years in logistics, returning to full-time work after a planned career break to care for a family member. Recently completed a certificate in supply chain analytics.*

A note on dates

You may have heard advice to show only years (2023 – 2025) instead of months, to make a gap less visible. Used on older roles, that's fine and common. Used to blur a recent gap, it often backfires: recruiters notice and ask, and then it looks like you were hiding something. **For your most recent role, use months.**

4. The Gap Explanation Bank

This is the heart of the kit. Find the reason closest to yours. For each one you get four versions of the same message, so your résumé, cover letter, LinkedIn and interview all tell **one consistent story**:

- **Résumé line**, for your experience section
- **Cover letter sentence**, for one sentence near the end of your letter
- **LinkedIn wording**, for your About section or a career-break entry
- **20-second interview answer**, for when they ask about it

Replace everything in [brackets]. Keep it short. Then use the same version everywhere.

1. Laid off, recent (under 6 months)

Résumé: Job search following company-wide restructuring | [Month Year] – Present

Cover letter: *After my role was eliminated in [company]'s restructuring in [month], I've been looking specifically for a position where I can [what you do best], which is what drew me to this one.*

LinkedIn: *My role at [company] was one of [number / many] affected by a restructuring in [month]. I'm now looking for my next role in [field], ideally [type of company or team].*

Interview: *"I was part of a restructuring at [company] in [month] that cut [scope]. Before that I [one result]. Since then I've been selective, and this role stood out because [reason]."*

2. Laid off, longer search (6 months or more)

Résumé: Career transition: job search and upskilling | [Month Year] – Present - [Course or certificate, year] - [Freelance, volunteer or project work]

Cover letter: *Since my role at [company] ended in [month year], I've used the time to [course / project], which has kept my [skill] current and given me [new skill].*

LinkedIn: *Since my role at [company] ended in [month year], I've completed [course] and [project / freelance work]. I'm ready to bring [core strength] to a [type of] team.*

Interview: *"The market in [industry] has been slow, so I've used the time deliberately: [course] and [project]. My skills are more current now than when I left."*

3. Caring for a family member

Résumé: Career break: family caregiving | [Month Year] – [Month Year / Present]

Cover letter: *I took time away from work to care for a family member. That's now settled, and I'm fully available and keen to return to [field].*

LinkedIn: *I took a planned career break to care for a family member. I'm now returning to [field] and looking for roles in [area].*

Interview: *"I was caring for [a family member] after [surgery / an illness]. That's resolved now, and I'm fully available. I kept up with [field] by [activity]."*

4. Health or recovery

You never have to give details about your health.

Résumé: Career break: personal matter (resolved) | [Month Year] – [Month Year]

Cover letter: *After taking some time away to deal with a personal matter that's now fully resolved, I'm ready and excited to return to [field].*

LinkedIn: *After a short career break, I'm returning to [field] and looking for [type of role].*

Interview: *"I took some time off for a personal matter that's fully resolved. I'm rested and very focused on getting back to [work]."*

5. Studying or retraining

Résumé: [Course / certificate name], [Provider] | [Month Year] – [Month Year] - [One project or skill you can point to]

Cover letter: *I recently completed [course], where I [project / skill]. It's given me exactly the [skill] this role asks for.*

LinkedIn: *Recently completed [course] at [provider], focused on [topic]. Looking to apply it in a [role] role.*

Interview: *"After my last role ended, I decided to strengthen [skill], so I completed [course]. My final project was [project], which is close to what this team does."*

6. Freelance or contract work

Résumé: Freelance [your role] | Self-employed | [Month Year] – Present - [Type of work] for [number] clients, including [type of client] - [One result]

Cover letter: *Since [month], I've been working freelance as a [role] for [type of clients], which has sharpened my [skill]. I'm now looking for a permanent team to grow with.*

LinkedIn: *Working freelance as a [role] since [month], helping [type of clients] with [what you do]. Open to full-time roles in [field].*

Interview: *"I've been freelancing for [clients], doing [work]. I enjoyed it, but I miss being part of a team and working on something long-term."*

7. Relocation

Résumé: Relocation to [city / country] | [Month Year] – [Month Year]

Cover letter: *I recently relocated to [city] and am now settled and looking for my next role locally.*

LinkedIn: *Recently relocated to [city]. Looking for [role] opportunities in the area or remote.*

Interview: *"We moved to [city] for [reason]. That took a few months to settle, and now I'm fully focused on finding the right role here."*

8. Career change in progress

Résumé: Career transition to [new field] | [Month Year] – Present - [Course / certificate] - [Project, volunteer work or freelance work in the new field]

Cover letter: *After [years] in [old field], I'm moving into [new field]. I've already [course / project], and I bring [transferable skill] that most candidates new to this field don't have.*

LinkedIn: *[Old role] moving into [new field]. [Number] years of [transferable skill], now focused on [new field] through [course / project].*

Interview: *"The layoff made me step back and choose [new field] on purpose. I've already done [project], and my [years] in [old field] give me [advantage]."*

9. Parental leave

Résumé: Career break: parental leave | [Month Year] – [Month Year]

Cover letter: *After a period of parental leave, I'm returning to work and looking for a role where I can [contribution].*

LinkedIn: *Returning to [field] after parental leave. Looking for [type of role].*

Interview: *"I took time off when [my child was born]. Childcare is arranged, and I'm ready and excited to get back to [work]."*

10. Burnout or a planned break

Résumé: Planned career break | [Month Year] – [Month Year]

Cover letter: *After a planned break, I'm returning with a clear focus on [type of work], which is why this role caught my attention.*

LinkedIn: *Back from a planned career break with a clear focus on [area]. Looking for [role].*

Interview: *"After [years] in a demanding role, I took a planned break to reset. I'm back with a much clearer idea of the work I do best, which is [area]."*

5. Turn your gap time into experience

Most people underestimate what they did during their gap. They think “I was just looking for a job” when actually they took a course, helped a friend’s business, volunteered or managed a big family situation. Those things count. Use this worksheet to find them.

Courses, certificates, workshops (including free ones)

Paid work of any kind: freelance, contract, temporary, cash-in-hand, helping a friend’s business

Volunteering: what did you organise, fix, manage or teach?

Projects: a website, a portfolio, an event, a renovation, a side business

Skills you used or improved: budgeting, scheduling, a new tool, a language

Now pick the **two strongest items** and write them as bullets under your gap line, using the formula in the next chapter.

Nothing to write yet? Start one thing this week: a free online course in your field, a few hours of volunteering, or helping a small business with something you're good at. In two weeks it's real, and you can add it.

6. Rewrite your bullet points

Your gap line gets attention for a second. Your bullet points are what get you the interview. Most résumés list duties ("Responsible for…"). Strong résumés list **results**.

The bullet formula

Action verb + what you did + result (number if possible)

Before and after

Before (duty)	After (result)
Responsible for customer support tickets	Resolved 40+ customer tickets a day and cut average response time from 2 days to under 1
Managed social media accounts	Grew Instagram from 3,000 to 11,000 followers in 12 months with a weekly content plan
Handled invoices and payments	Processed 300+ invoices a month and reduced late payments by 25% with a new reminder routine
Trained new staff	Trained 12 new team members, cutting onboarding time from 4 weeks to 2
Worked on warehouse operations	Reorganised picking routes, reducing order errors by 30% in one quarter
Helped with events	Coordinated 8 company events for up to 200 guests, all on budget

No exact numbers?

An honest estimate is fine (“about 20%”, “around 15 clients”). If there’s no number at all, describe the outcome: *“…which became the standard process for the whole team.”*

Strong action verbs

Increased · reduced · launched · built · led · coordinated · resolved · improved · streamlined · negotiated · trained · delivered · organised · created · managed

Your turn: rewrite three bullets

1. Before:

After:

2. Before:

After:

3. Before:

After:

7. Your cover letter

Three cover letter templates are included. Pick the one that fits:

Letter	Use when
A. Recent layoff	Your role ended in the last few months
B. Longer gap	You've been out of work for 6 months or more
C. Career pivot	You're applying in a different field from your last job

How every letter is built

1. **Opening:** the job you're applying for and one specific reason you want *this* one.
2. **Proof:** one or two results that match what the job ad asks for.
3. **The gap:** one sentence from the Gap Explanation Bank. Never more.
4. **Close:** why you'd be good for them, and a polite next step.

Keep it under one page, about 250 to 350 words. The gap sentence goes near the end, never in the first paragraph. Lead with what you can do.

Make it specific

The fastest way to stand out is one sentence that could only be written for this company: something from their website, a recent piece of news, or a line from the job ad. *"I noticed you're expanding your customer team in Germany, and I've managed German-speaking accounts for three years"* beats any generic opening.

8. Getting past the robots (ATS)

Many companies use an applicant tracking system (ATS) to collect and sort applications. It reads your résumé as text and helps recruiters search and filter. You don't need to game it. You just need to make sure it can read your résumé properly and that the right words are in it.

ATS checklist

- ☐ One column, no tables, text boxes or graphics (the templates already do this)
- ☐ Standard headings: *Summary*, *Experience*, *Education*, *Skills*
- ☐ Your name and contact details in the main text, not in the header or footer
- ☐ Dates in a consistent format (for example *Jun 2025 – Present*)
- ☐ A common font (the templates use Calibri)
- ☐ File saved as PDF, unless the job asks for Word
- ☐ File name: *Firstname-Lastname-Resume.pdf*
- ☐ No spelling mistakes (read it out loud once)

Keyword matching worksheet

Open the job ad. Find the skills, tools and phrases it mentions more than once or lists as "required". Check that the ones you genuinely have appear in your résumé, ideally using the same words.

Keyword from the job ad	In my résumé?	Where / how
	☐	
	☐	
	☐	
	☐	
	☐	
	☐	
	☐	
	☐	

Only add keywords that are true for you. A recruiter will ask about every one of them.

9. Your LinkedIn “Open to Work” profile

Recruiters often check LinkedIn right after reading your résumé. Make sure it tells the same story.

Headline (fill in)

> *[Your role] | [Key skill] & [key skill] | Open to [type of role] roles*

Example: Customer Success Manager | Retention & Onboarding | Open to CSM roles in SaaS

About section (fill in)

> *I’m a [role] with [number] years of experience in [field], and what I’m best at is [strength].*
>
> *At [company], I [result with a number]. I also [second result].*
>
> *[Your LinkedIn sentence from the Gap Explanation Bank.]*
>
> *I’m now looking for [type of role] at [type of company], especially where [what you care about]. Feel free to reach out.*

Quick wins

- Turn on **Open to Work**. You can choose to show it to recruiters only, if you prefer.

- If your gap is longer than a few months, add a **career break** entry so the timeline matches your résumé.
- Add any courses from your gap under *Licenses & certifications*.
- Make sure job titles and dates match your résumé exactly.

10. Before and after: a full example

Here is how one (made-up) résumé changes using this kit. Dana worked in marketing for six years and was laid off nine months ago.

Before

> ***Dana Reyes***
> *Marketing Coordinator, BrightPath Software | Mar 2019 – Feb 2026*
>
> - *Responsible for social media*
> - *Helped with email campaigns*
> - *Worked with the sales team on events*

What's wrong: The duties don't show results, and the résumé simply stops in February 2026. The nine months since then raise a question and offer no answer.

After

> ***Dana Reyes***
> *Marketing coordinator with 6 years in B2B software. Strongest in email and social campaigns that bring in qualified leads.*
>
> ***Career transition: job search and upskilling*** *| Feb 2026 – Present*
>
> - *Completed HubSpot Email Marketing Certification (2026)*
> - *Freelance email campaigns for 2 local businesses; one newsletter reached a 41% open rate*
>
> ***Marketing Coordinator****, BrightPath Software | Mar 2019 – Feb 2026*
>
> - *Grew LinkedIn followers from 2,000 to 9,500 in 18 months with a weekly content plan*
> - *Ran monthly email campaigns that generated around 120 qualified leads per quarter*
> - *Coordinated 6 trade-show events with sales, each on budget*

What changed: a summary that leads with strength, one honest gap line with two real activities underneath, and bullets that show results. The gap is still there. It just isn't the interesting part anymore.

The full "after" version is included in your download as **Example-Resume-Filled.docx**, so you can see the layout with real text in it.

Final check before you hit send

- ☐ My gap is explained in one honest line (or not mentioned if under 3 months)
- ☐ My résumé, cover letter and LinkedIn use the **same** gap wording
- ☐ Every job has at least two bullets with a result
- ☐ My summary is tailored to this job
- ☐ The job ad's key words that are true for me appear in my résumé
- ☐ I read everything out loud once
- ☐ Saved as PDF with a clear file name
- ☐ My cover letter mentions one specific thing about this company

When they invite you to interview

Your résumé got you in the door. The next question you'll hear is "So, what happened at your last job?" If you'd like word-for-word answers for that moment, a 30-day plan and a full set of interview worksheets, look for the companion guide: **Laid Off to Interview-Ready in 30 Days**.

What’s in your download

File	What it is
Gap-Proof-Resume-Kit-Guide.pdf	This guide
Resume-1-Classic.docx	One-page résumé template
Resume-2-Experienced.docx	Two-page résumé template
Resume-3-Career-Change.docx	Résumé template with skills section first
Cover-Letter-A-Recent-Layoff.docx	Cover letter for a recent layoff
Cover-Letter-B-Longer-Gap.docx	Cover letter for a gap of 6+ months
Cover-Letter-C-Career-Pivot.docx	Cover letter for changing fields
Example-Resume-Filled.docx	Dana’s full “after” résumé, as a layout example

All files open in Microsoft Word, Google Docs and Pages.

Good luck. Your gap is one line. Make the rest of the page count.